Robby had known Laura for months, maybe a year. They walked the dam walls together, swapped small jokes, shared lunch scraps, and argued over which side of the reservoir was best for fishing in the late afternoon. A close friendship had been easy, safe. Familiar. But one evening, something shifted.

He had been helping her carry a basket of fresh vegetables from the small garden they'd planted behind the school. The sun was low, painting the world in soft gold and long shadows. Laura tripped slightly over a loose stone. Without thinking, Robby reached for her arm, steadying her, his hand grabbing hers.

Neither pulled away. The contact was brief, but Robby felt it, something light, electric, quiet. Laura's cheeks flushed faintly, though she didn't say anything. She simply smiled, that easy, small smile that felt like it was meant only for him.

They walked the rest of the way in silence holding hands. It was different, weighted, aware. Robby noticed the way the light caught her hair, the curve of her hand as she gripped the basket, the soft cadence of her steps. He had noticed all of these things before, but now they seemed… important.

Later, while arranging tools for a small repair on the school's irrigation system, Laura handed him a wrench with a grin. "Here, you're better with this," she said casually.

Robby's hand lingered slightly longer than necessary as he took it. "Thanks," he said softly. Nothing more. The air between them had subtly shifted. He couldn't put it into words, and he didn't try. But he felt it in the way his chest throbbed, in the sudden awareness of her nearness. In the way she was able to ease through the defensive space he had built to protect himself all these years. Something he hadn't realized was missing, until now.

By the time they finished, the sun had dipped behind the distant hills. Robby found himself walking a little slower, glancing at her profile as they passed the school gate. He caught her eyes, and she looked back with the same quiet attentiveness he felt. No words were exchanged, and none were needed. Something unspoken had begun.

That evening, back at the farm, Nina padded up and brushed against his legs, reminding him that some parts of life stayed simple. But Robby's thoughts kept drifting to Laura. They had been close before but something had shifted, subtle as a whisper, and he knew it wasn't just friendship anymore.

The sun had barely risen when Robby was already out at the half-finished house, hammer in hand, measuring angles, fitting boards. By habit, he expected solitude, but soon enough, Laura appeared, carrying a ten pound box of nails.

"Morning," she said, brushing dirt from her hands. "I brought these. Thought you could use an extra pair of hands."

Robby nodded, a small smile tugging at his lips. "Thanks." It was the kind of exchange that carried no weight, yet somehow carried everything. The surprise and blush though when she walked up, casually kissed him on the cheek and went to set the nails down on the table was priceless.

They fell into an easy rhythm, moving boards, tightening screws, adjusting panels. Neither spoke more than necessary. Their hands brushed occasionally when passing tools, and each time, Robby's chest would tighten just slightly, enough to make him aware of it. Laura didn't seem to notice, or pretended not to, but her small, faint smiles made him notice anyway.

At lunch, they shared a quiet corner of the house. Robby unwrapped a piece of jerky he'd smoked earlier that week; Laura had brought fruit from the small orchard behind the school.

"You've got a lot of patience," she said softly, biting into an apple.

"I learned it the hard way," Robby replied, and neither said anything else. The words weren't necessary. Their routines, the shared tasks, the quiet companionship, said more than a conversation ever could.

Days blurred into weeks. They checked each other's work: a misaligned board corrected, a beam steadied together, panels adjusted in the fading sun. Occasionally, Robby would catch Laura studying a corner of the house he'd reinforced differently from his plans. "You think I'm overdoing it?" he'd ask.

She would glance at him, expression neutral, then tilt her head ever so slightly. "Maybe," she said, "Sometimes it feels like a lot of effort for something that won't be here in twenty years. But still, you'll have a decade with it right? So it might as well be overly sturdy." Her approval was quiet, understated, but to Robby, it was like a small medal pinned on his chest.

Sometimes, after the work was done, they lingered. Laura would hand him a tool and let her fingers brush his palm. He would pass a board, feeling her hand graze his. Neither acknowledged it, and that made it worse, and better, because both knew something was there, but neither wanted to be the first to admit it. Other times Robby thought maybe Laura just enjoyed torturing him and watching him blush.

One evening, Robby leaned back against a post, brushing sweat from his brow. "I think this could be our house someday," he said lightly.

Laura looked at him, startled for a second. "Our… house?"

"Yeah," he said quickly, realizing how the words sounded, his defensive walls started to rise again. "I mean… not like… not *that* kind of our. Just… a house we work on together. As friends I guess."

Laura's cheeks tinged pink. She ducked her head and laughed quietly, glancing at him sideways. "Of course. But I kind of like the idea of.. Well… our."

"Yeah. Our," Robby said, heart hammering and knocking down the defense he tried to build.

They both knew the unspoken truth, that there was more in the silence between them, in the way they moved together, in the way they watched the sun fall across the beams and panels. By the end of the evening, the house looked less like a half-finished project and more like a shared space, shaped not just by wood and nails, but by their rhythms, gestures, and quiet understanding.

By the time summer started to edge into late heat, Robby's world had grown wider, yet quieter in a way that surprised him. The routines of school, the weekly apprenticeship, the work on his house, the visits to Old Man Tom's farm, they were all steady, predictable rhythms. And through all of it, Laura had

become the most constant presence, her laughter and quiet observances threading themselves into the fabric of his days. The pair were fully like a couple in one of those old movies Sarah enjoyed watching repeatedly, peas and carrots.

It began with small things, almost imperceptible. Laura noticed when he'd stayed too long on a single wall and brought him water without being asked. Offering to steady a ladder when he thought he could manage alone. Sometimes she would bring snacks or small gifts from the garden, an apple, a sprig of mint, a jar of dried herbs, and leave them by his workbench with a sly, knowing smile. He began to anticipate these gestures, feeling warmth in his chest before realizing why.

One evening, as the sun dipped behind the distant hills, painting the unfinished walls in molten gold, Robby sat on the threshold of his door, tired, smeared with sawdust and sweat. Laura leaned against the frame beside him, quietly watching him inspect a small crack he'd noticed along one of the beams.

"You're too hard on yourself," she said softly.

Robby glanced at her, surprised. "I… I'm just checking. It's my responsibility. If it's off, it could… it could fail later."

She nudged his shoulder gently. "That's why I'm here. You don't have to carry it alone."

For a moment, he froze, not used to anyone offering help without expectation. He had always been the one to solve problems, to keep things from breaking, to manage consequences. But her presence didn't feel like pressure. It felt like permission, not to relax entirely, but to be human.

"You… you mean that?" he asked quietly.

"Of course," she said, smiling faintly. "I've got your back. Always." Then gave him a peck on the cheek to punctuate the deal.

It was a simple promise, but it struck him harder than any praise, any reward, or any recognition he had ever received. The world outside was still dangerous, unpredictable. His instincts still told him to prepare, to anticipate, to protect. But with Laura here, he could let himself pause.

These moments began to accumulate as such things have a tendency to do. They shared long walks along the dam walls, sometimes silent, sometimes talking about trivial things, weather patterns, the odd bird they spotted, the way the sun glinted off the water.

Laura asked questions about his boar hunts, his repairs on the tractor, the mechanics of his little generator. Robby answered honestly, explaining details he would have never shared with anyone else. And she listened, really listened, without judgment or surprise. In turn Robby would listen intently when she started to go on about this or that thing she had learned in her nursing studies.

Steve and Sarah noticed it, too. One evening, Sarah leaned against the doorway as they both tightened the frame of the front wall. "He actually talks to her, you know," she said, voice teasing. "Not just grunts and gestures."

Steve, seated on a beam with a mug of synth-coffee, shook his head with a grin. "She makes him feel normal. Or as normal as a kid like him can be."

It wasn't all perfect. Robby still struggled to explain feelings, still bristled at certain words, still found silence easier than conversation at times. But Laura's patience created a quiet allowance for him to grow. She never demanded, never pressed. She more than simply existed in his life, consistently, unjudgmentally, and that constancy, more than any lesson, any repair, any achievement, taught him something he had never truly known: trust, emotional safety, and the first taste of what it meant to belong.

By the end of that summer, Robby realized the subtle shift. His house was no longer just timber and nails. It was a shared space of trust, of laughter, of quiet companionship. Steve and Sarah stopped by less to supervise and more to watch, sometimes quietly smiling at the changes in him.

And Laura? She was there, always. Sometimes holding a board, sometimes brushing sawdust from her hands, sometimes just sitting nearby. But always there. And slowly, almost imperceptibly, Robby started thinking of her not just as a friend, but as someone who mattered, someone whose presence steadied him more than any beam, any brace, any structure he had ever built.

The first step toward love, he realized quietly, was simply letting himself lean into it. And with Laura, for the first time, he dared.

One evening, Robby found himself stepping into Laura's house, carrying a small basket of eggs and herbs from Old Man Tom's farm. The smell of roasted vegetables and warm bread hit him immediately.

Laura's mother greeted him with a bright smile. "Robby! Laura will be happy you're back! How's Tom doing? Nina still being the guardian of all things farm related?" She ushered him in, grabbing the basket of eggs and herbs, setting them on the worn counter top.

Robby smiled, "Tom's going good, he can't seem to get rid of his cough but he also won't put down that pipe. Nina's great, it wasn't long after I arrived she gifted me with a mouse that scurried off into the field when she dropped it, and then she ran after it mewing angrily."

Laura's father, on the other hand, remained at the table, arms crossed, leaning back trying not to laugh and keep his typical stern demeanor. "Evening," he said, his tone neutral, almost guarded. His eyes, sharp and appraising, lingered on Robby a little longer than was comfortable.

Robby nodded politely. "Evening, sir."

Dinner was served, a quiet clatter of old utensils and polite conversation. Laura sat beside him, occasionally nudging him with her elbow or passing a bread roll. He found himself relaxing, if only a little.

Her father cleared his throat. "Laura's going to be starting her nursing studies full time soon. She's got an apprentice slot on the second ship… but if she proves herself, she might be able to move up to the first ship."

Laura's face lit up with excitement. "I… I just need to work hard, Dad."

Her father's expression softened slightly, but he still studied Robby. "And you, Robert… You're not a normal boy. Too independent. Too… unusual. I like that you're careful, responsible… but I need to be sure you can handle someone like Laura."

Robby met his gaze steadily. “Sir, I’ll take care of her. I promise.”

Laura’s mother chuckled, reaching over to pat Robby’s hand. “Don’t mind him. He’s just being a grouch. Being different is what got you on the first ship. Polite, capable, grown up in ways most boys can’t even imagine.”

Robby’s cheeks warmed. He didn’t know whether to laugh or bow his head in thanks. Laura squeezed his hand under the table.

Conversation shifted to the farm, school, and small village happenings. Robby found himself sharing stories about building his house, the beginning construction of the third ship, and even a few minor mishaps, all under Laura’s quiet encouragement. Her father interjected occasionally, challenging some of his methods, but Laura’s mother countered gently, praising his diligence.

By the time dessert arrived, Robby felt a curious mix of relief and unease. Laura’s father hadn’t fully accepted him, still being in typical dad protector mode, but her mother’s warmth, Laura’s quiet presence, and the sense that he was trusted in at least part of their world made it feel… possible.

Laura leaned toward him as he carried the empty plates to the sink. “See? Not so bad,” she whispered, her hair brushing his arm.

And somewhere beneath the lingering warmth of the dinner, a quiet truth settled in: for the first time, Robby could imagine a life where he belonged, where he mattered, and where the people he cared about might let him in, not just as a capable young man, but as someone who could be trusted with more than work and chores.